

Session 13: The Structure and Message of Genesis 1

Key Takeaways

- The six days of creation are framed by summary statements (1:1; 2:1) and descriptions (1:2; 2:2-3) that bring us from chaos to completion.
- Both parts of the frame begin with a summary about how God created “the skies and the land” (1:1 and 2:1). This clarifies for us what days one through six are all about.
- Both summaries are followed by an exposition or further description (1:2 and 2:2-3). The first one talks about the pre-creation state, and the second shows God resting on the seventh day after all has been completed.

The Literary Design of Genesis 1

The prologue (Gen. 1:1-2) and epilogue (Gen. 1:31-2:3) of Genesis 1 have been designed as a macro-frame around the internal sequence of six days.

1:1 Summary Prologue In the beginning, God created the skies and the land [7 words]	
1:2 Exposition of Prologue in 3 Lines Now, the land was wild and waste (תהו ובהו <i>tohu va-vohu</i>) and darkness was over the face of the deep abyss (תהום <i>tehom</i>) but the breath of <i>Elohim</i> was hovering over the face of the waters (המים <i>hammayim</i>) [7 x 2 words]	
Day 1	Day 4
Day 2	Day 5
Day 3	Day 6
2:1 Summary Epilogue Thus were finished the skies and the land and all their host	
2:2-3 Exposition of Epilogue in 3 Lines 1. And God completed on the seventh day his work which he had made [7 words]	
<i>Genesis 1 Themes.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).	

2. And he rested on the seventh day from all his work which he had **made** [7 words]
3. And God blessed the seventh day and sanctified it [7 words]
because on it he rested from all his work which God **created to make** [key word of 1:1]

Genesis 1 Themes. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

Notice how the key words of the opening prologue (i.e., “created,” “skies,” “land”) as well as the 1x7 and 2x7 design of 2:1-2 are taken up and completed in the prologue with the same words and the 3x7 design.

This design structure acts as an envelope around the sequence of six days, with a clear emphasis on the sevenfold symbolism of God’s actions and the culmination of the entire narrative on the seventh day.

Reflection Question

How would you summarize what the frame around the six days is all about (Gen. 1:1-2, 2:1-3)?